

Probability through ticket triage

Lecture 1 · Worked student edition

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A ticket-routing review

A service desk checks whether an LLM routes tickets to the appropriate teams. A reviewer supplies reference decisions; the model supplies classifications. What would it mean for them to agree?

We will compare the reviewer reference outcome with the model classification ticket by ticket. The example is hypothetical. The reviewer decisions are operational references, not claims of error-free ground truth.

Six reviewed tickets

For this hypothetical audit, the model uses a 0.50 threshold separately on each destination.

Ticket	Request	Reviewer	Model
t_1	Duplicate charge; cannot log in	Billing + Account Support	Billing
t_2	Duplicate monthly charge	Billing	Billing
t_3	MFA phone change; cannot log in	Account Support	Account Support
t_4	Delivery-status question	Other	Account Support
t_5	Duplicate renewal charge	Billing	Billing
t_6	Locked after password reset	Account Support	Account Support

What does the table count as an agreement?

For t_1 , the model scores are 0.55 for Billing and 0.35 for Account Support. The reviewer reference includes both destinations. Exact agreement means the model classification equals the full reviewer reference outcome.

Which rows agree?

Mark exact agreement between the reviewer reference and model classification. How many of the six records agree?

Exact agreements occur on t_2, t_3, t_5, t_6 . Thus the observed agreement fraction is $4/6 = 2/3$.

What does four out of six describe?

The table records four agreements. Is $4/6$ a probability for every question about this model?

It is first an observed proportion in these six records. It becomes the probability of agreement if the experiment is to select one of these six ticket IDs uniformly. A claim about future tickets needs a target population and assumptions linking this audit to it.

Equal-likelihood counting

If one of the six ticket IDs is selected uniformly, what is the probability that the selected record shows agreement?

The classical rule for a finite set of equally likely cases is $P(E) = |E|/|\Omega|$. Here each ID has probability $1/6$ and four IDs show agreement, so $P(\text{agreement}) = 4/6 = 2/3$. The uniform selection rule justifies equal weights for IDs in this experiment.

The cases being counted matter

The occupied reviewer/model pairs are: both destinations / Billing (t_1); Billing only / Billing (t_2, t_5); Account only / Account (t_3, t_6); Other / Account (t_4). If one pair type were selected uniformly, what agreement probability would result?

Two of four occupied types are agreements, so the answer under uniform selection among types is $2/4 = 1/2$. It differs from $4/6$ under uniform selection among ticket IDs because the categories contain unequal numbers of records.

A larger set of possible label pairs

There are four possible reviewer reference types and two model classes. How many pairs are possible in their full Cartesian product? How many appear here?

There are $4 \times 2 = 8$ possible pairs in the full product. Four are occupied in this six-row table. Uniform weighting over eight pairs would be a third selection rule and is not implied by the audit.

Frequency and repeated observations

Does an agreement fraction of 4/6 establish a long-run agreement rate for future tickets?

No. A frequency account connects probability to relative frequency in a specified repeatable process. If I_i indicates agreement on trial i , the observed frequency after n trials is $n^{-1} \sum_{i=1}^n I_i$; a limiting account relates this sequence to a probability p . Six observations alone establish no such limit and do not establish that future tickets follow the same process.

Belief and evidence

Suppose an analyst assigns probability 0.8 to agreement on the next ticket, given this audit and other information. Does the table alone determine 0.8?

No. A subjective account treats probability as a degree of belief given information. The assignment needs stated information or judgments and must be coherent with the analyst's other probability assignments. An evidential account also needs a specified rule connecting evidence and background assumptions to a number.

What the earlier views contribute

What does each account emphasize: equal-likelihood counting, frequency, belief, or evidential support? What remains necessary for a calculation?

The accounts emphasize symmetry, repeated observations, information-conditioned belief, and evidential support. A calculation still needs specified outcomes, an event and a probability assignment. A propensity interpretation instead locates chance in a specified physical or randomized mechanism.

A second question: a random chord

A chord is selected at random from a circle. What is the probability that its length exceeds the side of an inscribed equilateral triangle?

The phrase “at random” does not say how the chord is generated. Bertrand’s chord problem has answers $1/3$, $1/2$ and $1/4$ under different sampling procedures. We will pose the question here and return to its full resolution in the supplement.

What must a probability model specify?

The ticket audit and the chord question both involve uncertainty. What mathematical objects would let us state the outcomes, the event and its probability?

Kolmogorov's set-based framework specifies a sample space Ω , an event collection $\mathcal{F}$, and a probability measure P . We now build these objects from the ticket-selection experiment.

Specify the ticket experiment

The six records are fixed. We select one ticket ID uniformly. What varies, and what are the possible outcomes?

The selected ID varies. The sample space is $\Omega = \{t_1, t_2, t_3, t_4, t_5, t_6\}$. The ticket contents and labels are fixed data in this experiment.

Build the Billing event

Which ticket IDs have Billing in the reviewer's reference outcome? Write them as a set B .

$B = \{t_1, t_2, t_5\}$. An event is a set of outcomes in the sample space. The statement "Billing is required" occurs exactly when the selected ID belongs to B .

Build the Account Support event

Which IDs have Account Support in the reviewer's reference outcome? Write this event as A .

$A = \{t_1, t_3, t_6\}$. The two events overlap because t_1 requires both destinations.

Other as a complement

In this two-destination question, “Other” means neither Billing nor Account Support is required. Express this event using A and B .

$O = (B \cup A)^c = \{t_4\}$. The complement is taken relative to Ω . It does not mean the ticket is unreviewed or unknown; another team may handle it.

Union and intersection

Use the ticket IDs to find $B \cap A$ and $B \cup A$. Interpret each event in words.

$B \cap A = \{t_1\}$ means both destinations are required. $B \cup A = \{t_1, t_2, t_3, t_5, t_6\}$ means at least one is required. “Or” in a union is inclusive.

Count the union without double-counting

Why is the number of IDs in $B \cup A$ not $|B|+|A|$? Calculate the probability under uniform selection.

The shared ID t_1 appears in both marginal counts. Split the union into disjoint parts:

$B \setminus A = \{t_2, t_5\}$, $A \setminus B = \{t_3, t_6\}$, and $B \cap A = \{t_1\}$. Hence $P(B \cup A) = (2 + 2 + 1)/6 = 5/6$. Equivalently, $3/6 + 3/6 - 1/6 = 5/6$.

Pause and check the events

Without looking back, list the IDs in B , A , $B \cap A$, $B \cup A$ and O . Explain the overlap.

$B = \{t_1, t_2, t_5\}$; $A = \{t_1, t_3, t_6\}$; $B \cap A = \{t_1\}$; $B \cup A = \{t_1, t_2, t_3, t_5, t_6\}$; and $O = \{t_4\}$. t_1 requires both named destinations.

The probability-space triplet

For uniform selection from the six ticket IDs, specify the sample space, the events and the probability assignment.

□

$$\Omega = \{t_1, t_2, t_3, t_4, t_5, t_6\}.$$

$\mathcal{F} = 2^\Omega$, the collection of all subsets of Ω .

For every $E \in \mathcal{F}$, $P(E) = |E|/6$.

Thus $P(B) = 3/6 = 1/2$ and $P(B \cup A) = 5/6$.

Outcomes, events and probability values

Classify each object: t_2 , B , and $P(B) = 1/2$. Which one is the outcome? Which is an event? Which is a number?

t_2 is an outcome in Ω . B is an event, a subset of Ω . $P(B) = 1/2$ is a number assigned to that event. The measure takes events as input.

Requirements on the event collection

If E is an event, should “not E ” also be an event? If $E_1, E_2, \dots$ are events, what about “at least one occurs”?

A sigma-algebra $\mathcal{F}$ on Ω satisfies:

1. $\Omega \in \mathcal{F}$.
2. If $E \in \mathcal{F}$, then $E^c \in \mathcal{F}$.
3. If $E_1, E_2, \dots \in \mathcal{F}$, then $\bigcup_{n=1}^{\infty} E_n \in \mathcal{F}$.

It therefore contains $\emptyset$ too. In the finite ticket model, $\mathcal{F} = 2^{\Omega}$ satisfies these conditions.

Kolmogorov's probability axioms

What conditions should a probability assignment satisfy on events?

For $P: \mathcal{F} \rightarrow [0, 1]$:

1. **Nonnegativity:** $P(E) \geq 0$ for every $E \in \mathcal{F}$.
2. **Normalization:** $P(\Omega) = 1$.
3. **Countable additivity:** for pairwise disjoint $E_1, E_2, \dots \in \mathcal{F}$, $P(\bigcup_{n=1}^{\infty} E_n) = \sum_{n=1}^{\infty} P(E_n)$.

For example, B and B^c are disjoint and exhaustive, and $P(B) + P(B^c) = 3/6 + 3/6 = 1$.

A random variable for Billing

Can we record numerically whether Billing is required? Define X_B on the ticket outcomes.

$X_B: \Omega \rightarrow \mathbb{R}$, where $X_B(t) = 1$ if $t \in B$ and $X_B(t) = 0$ if $t \notin B$. The values are 1, 1, 0, 0, 1, 0 on $t_1, \dots, t_6$ respectively. A random variable is a set function from outcomes to the real line. The selected outcome is random; for a given outcome, the function value is fixed.

Image of a set of outcomes

For $A = \{t_1, t_3, t_6\}$, what values does X_B produce? Write the image $X_B(A)$.

$X_B(A) = \{X_B(t) : t \in A\} = \{0, 1\}$. The image is a set of real values, not a set of ticket IDs.

Inverse image and probability

Which outcomes produce the value 1? Express them as $X_B^{-1}(\{1\})$ and calculate $P(X_B = 1)$.

$X_B^{-1}(\{1\}) = \{t \in \Omega : X_B(t) = 1\} = B = \{t_1, t_2, t_5\}$. Therefore $P(X_B = 1) = P(B) = 3/6 = 1/2$. The inverse image is an event; it need not be an inverse function.

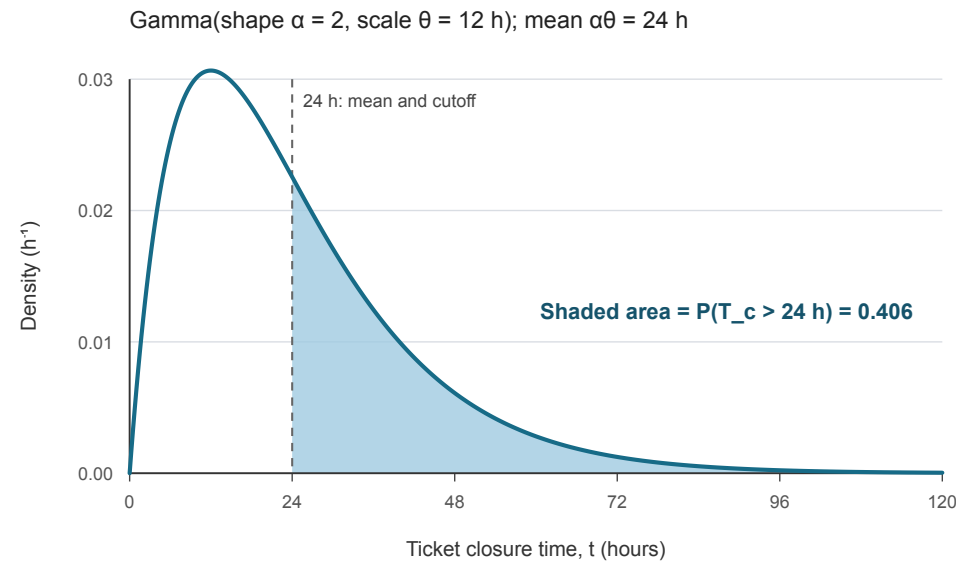
A continuous ticket-time question

Let T_c be the closure time, in hours, of a ticket from a specified process. Under an illustrative Gamma model with shape 2 and scale 12 hours, calculate $P(T_c > 24)$.

The model is stipulated for illustration, not estimated from the six-ticket audit. Its mean is $\alpha\theta = 2(12) = 24$ hours. The Gamma shape-scale density is $f(t) = \frac{t}{144}e^{-t/12}$ for $t \geq 0$. The required probability is the area under this density to the right of 24 hours.

From counting to integration

For the six equally likely ticket IDs, an event probability is found by counting IDs. For continuous closure time under this density, what replaces counting individual durations?



For a ticket-ID event C , $P(C) = |C|/6 = \sum_{t_i \in C} P(\{t_i\})$. Under a continuous density model, probabilities are integrals over ranges. A density value is not itself a probability. The shaded right-tail area is $P(T_c > 24) = \int_{24}^{\infty} \frac{t}{144} e^{-t/12} dt$.

Evaluate the Gamma tail

Evaluate $\int_{24}^{\infty} \frac{t}{144} e^{-t/12} dt$ using $u = t/12$. State the interpretation.

With $u = t/12$, $t = 12u$ and $dt = 12du$: $\int_2^{\infty} ue^{-u} du = [-(u+1)e^{-u}]_2^{\infty} = 3e^{-2} \approx 0.406$. Under the stipulated model, about 0.406 of the probability lies above 24 hours.

The closure-time probability space

State the triplet for the closure-time calculation and define its random variable explicitly.

$\Omega_c = [0, \infty)$, $\mathcal{F}_c = \mathcal{B}([0, \infty))$, and for $E \in \mathcal{F}_c$, $P_c(E) = \int_E (t/144)e^{-t/12} dt$. Define $T_c: \Omega_c \rightarrow [0, \infty)$ by $T_c(t) = t$. Then $T_c^{-1}((24, \infty)) = (24, \infty)$ and $P_c(T_c > 24) = 3e^{-2} \approx 0.406$. This is a canonical space modeling closure time alone.

Worked check: neither named destination

Under uniform selection from the six audited IDs, find the probability of “Other,” meaning neither Billing nor Account Support is required.

$O = (B \cup A)^c = \{t_4\}$. Thus $P(O) = 1/6$.

Worked check: exactly one destination

Find the event and probability that exactly one of Billing and Account Support is required.

$$(B \setminus A) \cup (A \setminus B) = \{t_2, t_3, t_5, t_6\}.$$

Therefore its probability is $4/6 = 2/3$.

Worked check: exact agreement

Let C be the event that the model classification equals the reviewer reference outcome. Find C and its probability in the uniform ticket-ID experiment.

$C = \{t_2, t_3, t_5, t_6\}$, so $P(C) = 4/6 = 2/3$. This equals the observed agreement fraction because the model selects uniformly from this exact six-ticket audit.

Worked check: agreement as a random variable

Define $Y(t) = 1$ for exact agreement and 0 otherwise. Find $Y^{-1}(\{1\})$ and $P(Y = 1)$.

$Y^{-1}(\{1\}) = C = \{t_2, t_3, t_5, t_6\}$. Thus $P(Y = 1) = P(C) = 4/6 = 2/3$. The random variable records an outcome numerically; its inverse image is the event; the measure assigns that event a number.

Stopping point and continuation

State one distinction from today that is needed before interpreting an AI evaluation score as a future probability.

The audit agreement fraction describes six fixed records. A future-ticket probability requires a target population and a sampling or generation model. For each probability claim, identify outcomes, events and the probability assignment. Continue with more event and distribution problems before advancing to further theory.